

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

THE GIANT STEPS

- The Indian art market is currently at its strongest, with auction records being broken for iconic artists. Contemporary art sales are also on the rise
- The government has supported various cultural festivals, exhibitions, and heritage conservation projects and private organisations too have taken it upon themselves to place South Asian art onto the global stage
- We must also encourage art education across all demographics

ternational Airport. When it opens three years from now, it will be a confluence of ideas and conversations, a place of discovery, with engagement across a broad spectrum of audiences. The new KNMA will serve as a venue for visual arts, music, dance, and theatre, featuring a roster of exhibitions, permanent displays, and performances.

A collective endeavour: Promoting India's art and culture is a collective endeavour involving the government, cultural institutions, the arts and culture community, and patrons. By working together to promote and enhance India's cultural presence on the global stage, we can significantly elevate the nation's profile and influence. What might empower us as a country further is encouraging art education across all demographics—just like how it is in the West. Our country's children must have that access and interaction with high-quality art workshops and programmes. It will not just engage but also empower a new generation of children to dream a little bigger and not treat this as a parallel universe but as something within their reach—to consider exploring a future in art.

Through sustained support for Indian artists and cultural projects, we can harness our rich heritage as an important form of soft power. As we navigate this evolving landscape, the potential for India's cultural exports to make a lasting impact on the global stage is both exciting and promising. Embracing this will contribute to a more fulfilled interconnected global cultural dialogue. In a world that increasingly values cultural diplomacy, I have faith that sometimes the first step is the hardest, but the rewards are everlasting. ■

The author is the Founder of the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA)